

The Altai Mountains

A beautiful range of high mountains situated almost in the middle of Asia



Straddling an area where Russia, China, Mongolia, and Kazakhstan meet, the Altai stretch for 1,200 miles (2,000 km) across central Asia. Much of the range exceeds 10,000 ft (3,000 m) in height, and there are numerous glaciated peaks over 13,000 ft (4,000 m) in the Mongolian sections. The highest peak, Mount Belukha (14,783 ft/4,506 m), lies in the north at the headwaters

▽ GOLDEN MOUNTAINS

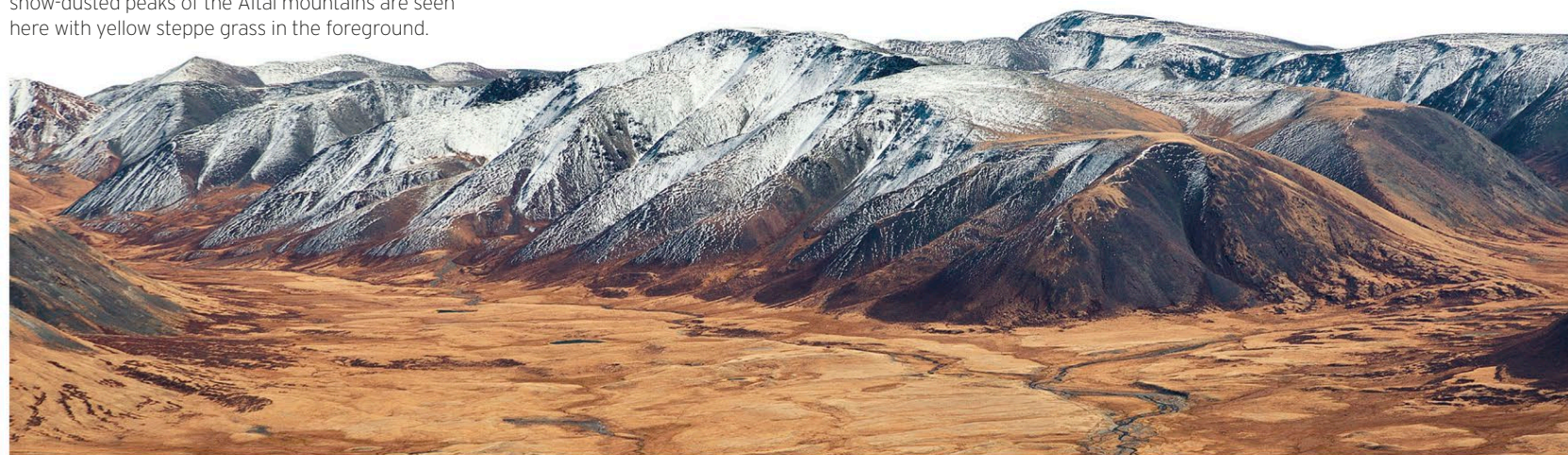
Altai means “gold peak” in Mongolian. The snow-dusted peaks of the Altai mountains are seen here with yellow steppe grass in the foreground.

of the Ob–Irtysh river system in Russian Siberia. In the east, the Altai merge into the high plateau of the Gobi desert (see pp.266–67) and the cold steppes of Mongolia. Partly because they include a variety of habitats—such as tundra, forest, and alpine vegetation—the Altai are home to a wide range of wildlife, including Siberian ibex and several species of deer, wolves, lynx, and brown bears.



◁ HEAVY FRAME

Resembling a heavily built goat, the Siberian ibex is typically found on steep rocky slopes above the tree line. It feeds on small shrubs, grass, and sedges.



The Tian Shan Mountains

One of the world's longest and highest mountain ranges, boasting more than 60 peaks that exceed 20,000 ft (6,000 m) in height



Also known as the Tien Shan, the Tian Shan consists of a series of subranges that extend through Kyrgyzstan, a part of Kazakhstan, and western China. Their overall length is about 1,700 miles (2,800 km), which is longer than the Himalayas. The peaks above 13,000 ft (4,000 m)—including the highest, Victory Peak at 24,406 ft (7,439 m)—are capped by glaciers. The Chinese words *Tian Shan* mean “heavenly mountains.” The range has been listed as a World Heritage Site—partly because of its unique and rich biodiversity, as well as its diverse landscapes that contrast with the vast adjacent deserts.

▷ BLUE MOUNTAINS

A part of the Borohoros, one of the Tian Shan's subranges, appears vivid blue due to atmospheric scattering of blue-wavelength light.

